



◀ THE ROMAN ARMY

Well organized and highly trained, the Roman army conquered vast areas along the Mediterranean and beyond. It was made up of Roman citizens as well as people from conquered territories in Africa, the Middle East, and elsewhere. One of the elite units of the army was the Praetorian Guard (left), which served as bodyguards for the emperors.

The curved shield protects the soldier's body.

JULIUS CAESAR

Julius Caesar (100–44 BCE) was one of the most powerful politicians and military leaders of ancient Rome. He conquered Gaul (modern-day France) and seized power in 47 BCE after defeating his rival, Pompey, in a civil war.



◀ AQUEDUCTS

The Romans built aqueducts (bridges that carry water over rivers and valleys) to supply public baths, fountains, farms, and more. Many of these ancient structures are still standing today, such as the Pont du Gard (left) in Nîmes, France.

ROMAN EMPIRE AT ITS HEIGHT ▶

The empire reached its greatest expanse around 117 CE. Extending all the way around the Mediterranean and up as far as Britain, it stretched 2,800 miles (4,500 km) from east to west and 2,300 miles (3,700 km) from north to south.



117–139 CE

To protect his massive empire, Emperor Hadrian builds defenses along frontiers.



EMPEROR HADRIAN
ON A ROMAN COIN

284–305 CE

The empire is now too big to manage, so Emperor Diocletian splits it in two: east and west.

312–330 CE

Emperor Constantine reunites the empire, but establishes his capital in modern-day Turkey rather than in Rome.

476 CE

Germanic chief Odoacer overthrows the last Western Roman emperor. The Eastern Empire will survive for another 1,000 years.